How College Students Change Their Writing for Different Audiences

Introduction

People tend to speak and write differently depending on who their audience is. Some become more respectful toward authority figures and more familiar with their peers. Because audience seems to shape the way people write, I wanted to see how this plays out for me and my fellow college students. This paper investigates how and why college students change their writing for different audiences.

Researchers have long studied how audience and purpose influence writing. Black examines how students adjust their persuasive writing based on their understanding of their audience, and Collin explains that writing choices are shaped by audience, purpose, and the situation in which the writing takes place. Together, these findings suggest that knowing who will read a text affects not only what a writer says but also how they choose to say it, and they help explain why a student might write a formal email to a professor but use short, casual language when texting a friend. Other studies look at how writers adapt to different situations. Cho and Choi examine how an intended audience affects the way students summarize information from sources, and Wong looks at how writers think about their audience and purpose while composing. Taken together, these four sources suggest that writing is more than putting thoughts onto paper. Writers also

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make decisions based on who they expect to read their work and what they want to accomplish.

To explore this question firsthand, I surveyed six college students about how they would write in five everyday situations: messaging a professor, a close friend, a boss, classmates, and a family member. Their answers showed a sharp contrast between writing to professors and writing to friends, and their written comments pointed to several factors behind their choices. With only six respondents, however, these findings are preliminary and should be read as a starting point rather than as evidence about college students in general.

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Methods

To collect primary data, I created a Google Forms survey titled "How College Students Change Their Writing for Different Audiences." A survey is a stronger fit for this project than interviews because it allows me to gather responses from many students without scheduling individual conversations, while still giving participants the chance to describe their own writing habits and explain their approach to different situations.

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The survey opens by asking whether participants are currently college or university students, followed by their major or general field of study and their year in college. These questions help me understand who responded and whether students from different academic backgrounds report different writing habits. Participants are also asked whether they change the way they write depending on who will read their message.

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Most of the survey consists of hypothetical situations involving five audiences: a professor, a close friend, a boss, classmates in a group chat, and a family member. In one example, participants imagine writing a message to a professor explaining that they will miss class. For each situation, participants choose from four preset styles: formal, with a greeting, explanation, and sign-off; short and polite, getting straight to the point; casual, in the writer's usual voice; and detailed, with background information and reasoning. Each question allows more than one answer, so the options are not mutually exclusive, and participants can use an "Other" field to write in their own responses or to note extenuating circumstances that might change how they would write. This design produces easily categorized data while leaving room to notice patterns I did not anticipate.

To analyze the responses, I counted how many respondents selected each preset style for each audience. Because of the multiple-answer format, these counts do not add up to the number of respondents. I then grouped the write-in responses by the factor each one described.

Results and Analysis

Six students responded to the survey between October 11 and October 18, 2026, and all six confirmed that they are currently college students. They came from a mix of fields: game design (programming), graphic design, a philosophy and biomedical science double major, electrical engineering, mechanical engineering, and computer science. Three were seniors, two were juniors, and one was a freshman. Most reported adjusting their writing often: two said they always change the way they write depending on the reader, three said often, and one said sometimes.

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Table 1 shows how many of the six respondents selected each style for each audience. Because respondents could choose more than one style, each count reflects the number of people who selected that style, not a share of a single total.

Table 1

Number of Respondents (out of 6) Who Selected Each Writing Style by Audience

Audience	Formal	Short and polite	Casual	Detailed	Write-in
Professor	5	3	0	2	1
Close friend	0	0	6	2	1
Boss	5	3	2	1	1
Classmates (group chat)	0	5	3	2	1
Family member	2	4	2	3	2

Note: Respondents could select more than one style per situation. "Write-in" counts respondents who typed a response in the "Other" field. Source: author's survey data.

The clearest pattern was the contrast between professors and close friends, the comparison I planned to focus on. For a professor, five of six respondents chose the formal style and none chose casual. For a close friend, the pattern reversed: all six chose casual, and no one chose formal or short and polite. Close friends were the only audience on which every respondent agreed. Two respondents (4 and 5) also selected the detailed style for friends, so even casual messages sometimes included background and reasoning.

Writing to a boss looked much like writing to a professor. Five respondents selected formal and three selected short and polite. Only two selected casual: Respondent 2, who chose casual as their only style for a boss, and Respondent 6, who combined casual with formal and explained that family ties with their boss relax their tone while they still try to stay professional.

Classmates and family members drew less formal and less consistent responses. No respondent chose formal for a group chat with classmates; five chose short and polite, and three chose casual. Family was the most varied audience. Every style was chosen by at least two respondents, and none was chosen by more than four: four selected short and polite, three selected detailed, and two each selected formal and casual. Across audiences, short and polite was the most flexible style. At least three respondents chose it for every audience except close friends.

Individual habits differed as well. Respondents 1 and 2 selected exactly one style in every situation, while Respondents 3 through 6 selected more than one style in at least four of the five situations. Even so, every respondent used at least three of the four preset styles across the five situations, and four of the six used all four.

Six of the write-in responses came from two respondents: Respondent 6 wrote one for every audience, and Respondent 3 wrote one for family. These explanations fell into four categories. The first was relationship and familiarity. Respondent 6 described two tones for classmates, one for classmates they treat as strangers and one that says “we’re in this together,” and a more relaxed tone with a boss who is also a relative. The second was the reader’s own tone: Respondent 6 tries to be as formal as possible with professors but loosens up if the professor replies casually. The third was language, since Respondent 6 writes a short, formal message to Chinese-speaking family members but a more detailed explanation to family who speak English. The fourth was writing conventions, as Respondent 3 wrote that messages to family would skip the greeting and sign-off but still use proper punctuation. Respondent 6 also noted using slang such as “bro” and “dude” with close friends.

These results largely match the research I reviewed. The sharp split between professors and friends reflects Collin's point that audience, purpose, and situation shape writing choices. Respondent 6's descriptions of how they picture different classmates are consistent with Black's finding that students adjust their writing based on their understanding of their audience, and with Wong's focus on how writers think about their audience as they compose. There are also discrepancies. Those studies examined persuasive writing, summarizing, and composing processes, while my scenarios involved short informational messages, so the comparison is indirect. My data are also self-reported, so they show what students say they would do rather than what they actually write. Respondent 1 said they always change their writing, yet chose short and polite for professors, classmates, and family alike, which suggests that students may understand "changing" their writing in subtler terms than switching between formal and casual. Finally, with six respondents, one person can shift the results considerably, and these patterns may not hold for a larger group.

Discussion

College students communicate with many different people throughout the day, and each interaction carries its own expectations. Studying how students adjust their writing is worthwhile because it offers insight into how they perceive tone and how tone relates to their purpose and audience. The survey results illustrate the range involved: every respondent used at least three different styles across just five situations.

Writing to a professor may call for respect and a clear explanation of the situation, whereas writing to a friend may prioritize getting the point across quickly with less

concern for formal grammar or complete sentences. These tones are not interchangeable, and using the wrong one could cause problems. The survey suggests that students recognize this. Most respondents chose formal writing for professors and bosses, while all six chose casual writing for close friends, which indicates that, for this group, the expectations for friends are especially well established. A message is most effective when its style fits the situation and communicates what the writer intends.

Collin's framework helps explain why. A writer has to consider more than the information being communicated, including what the reader already knows, how the reader might interpret the message, and what response the writer wants. Respondent 6's write-in answers show this kind of thinking: they adjust to a professor's tone, consider whether classmates are strangers or teammates, and change their language depending on which relatives will read the message. In these cases, the writer's choice depends on the specific reader and the relationship, not just the category of audience. College students move between several distinct audiences, such as professors, classmates, employers, friends, and family, often within a single day, which may make these decisions especially frequent for them.

Another question is whether students make these changes consciously. Some people might think carefully about their wording before emailing a professor, while others might adjust their writing automatically because they are familiar with the expectations of that situation. The survey offers a small hint of both. Five respondents said they change their writing often or always, but Respondent 3, who said they do so only sometimes, still selected four different styles across the five situations. This could mean that some adjustments happen without the writer noticing, although a single respondent is far too

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little evidence to say so with confidence. More broadly, the survey reflects what students report about themselves rather than directly observing how they write.

The main limitation of this research is its sample size. Six respondents is a very small data set, and my results may be biased as a result. A single respondent can change the pattern noticeably: Respondent 6 wrote five of the six write-in responses, and much of what I know about relationships, language, and a reader's tone comes from them alone. Because the survey was shared through Discord servers and personal contacts, the participants were also not a random sample of college students. Three of the six were seniors, four of the six studied programming, engineering, or computer science, and no sophomores responded. Recruiting students from a wider range of classes in the future would help balance this.

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The survey design adds further limitations. Hypothetical situations may not perfectly reflect how people actually write. A person might say they would send a formal email to a professor but use a different style when they are in a hurry or dealing with a stressful situation. The preset options also overlap, since a message can be both short and formal, which may be why several respondents selected more than one style. I counted each selection as written, but different respondents may have interpreted the options differently.

The survey also focuses on a limited number of situations. Students communicate with many other audiences, including strangers, online communities, customers, and people they meet through extracurricular activities. The responses therefore provide only a

partial view of how college students adjust their writing. Still, they offer a starting point for understanding common patterns in everyday communication.

Conclusion

Writing is a regular part of college life, but the way students communicate can change depending on who they are talking to and what they are trying to accomplish. A message to a professor may require a different approach than a text to a friend, even though both messages communicate similar information. In my survey, five of six students would write formally to a professor, while all six would write casually to a close friend. Research on audience and purpose suggests that these decisions are an important part of writing rather than something that only matters in academic assignments.

The survey of six students revealed several patterns. Professors and bosses were met mostly with formal or short and polite messages, close friends with casual ones, and classmates and family members with a wider mix. Short and polite messages worked as the most flexible style, appearing for every audience except close friends. The write-in responses also suggest that students' choices depend on more than formality. Relationship, the reader's own tone, language, and writing conventions all came up, which supports the idea that writing habits are more complicated than simply choosing between formal and casual language. Because the sample was so small, these patterns are preliminary.

Further research could test them with a larger and more diverse group of students from more colleges. Interviews would let students explain their choices in their own words,

and observing examples of their writing with their permission would show whether what students say they would write matches what they actually write. It could also compare how students communicate through different formats, such as emails, text messages, discussion boards, and social media. Overall, understanding how students adjust their writing can help explain how people communicate with different audiences and why the same person may write in several different ways.

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